

## Unit 3 – Computer Applications

### 1. Listen to the extract once more and fill in the gaps with the correct terms. (booklet page 17)

For as long as there has been computer hardware, there has also been computer software. But what is software?

Software is just instructions written by a \_\_\_\_\_<sup>1</sup>  
which tells the computer what to do. They are also known as  
' \_\_\_\_\_ '<sup>2</sup>.



Nothing much is simple about software. Software programs can have millions of  
\_\_\_\_\_<sup>3</sup>. If one line doesn't work, the whole program could break! Even the  
process of starting software goes by many different names in English. Perhaps the most correct  
technical term is ' \_\_\_\_\_ '<sup>4</sup>, as in "the man executed the computer program."  
Be careful, because this term also means (in another context) to put someone to death! Some  
other common verbs used to start a software program you will hear are  
' \_\_\_\_\_ '<sup>5</sup>, ' \_\_\_\_\_ '<sup>6</sup>, and even  
' \_\_\_\_\_ '<sup>7</sup> (when the software in question is an operating system).

Software normally has both features and bugs. Hopefully more of the former than the latter!  
When software has a bug there are a few things that can happen. The program can  
\_\_\_\_\_<sup>8</sup> and \_\_\_\_\_<sup>9</sup> with a confusing message.

This is not good. \_\_\_\_\_<sup>10</sup> do not like confusing \_\_\_\_\_<sup>11</sup>  
such as:

*site error: the file /home7/businfc6/public\_html/blog/wordpress/wp-content/plugins/seo-  
blog/core.php requires the ionCube PHP Loader ioncube\_loader\_lin\_5.2.so to be installed by  
the site administrator.*

Sometimes when software stops responding you are forced to manually  
\_\_\_\_\_<sup>12</sup> the program yourself by pressing some strange combination of keys  
such as ctrl-alt-delete.

Because of poor usability, documentation, and strange error messages, programming still seems  
very mysterious to most people. That's too bad, because it can be quite fun and rewarding to

\_\_\_\_\_ <sup>13</sup> software. To succeed, you just have to take everything in small steps, think very hard, and never give up.

I think everyone studying Information Technology should learn at least one programming language and write at least one program. Why? Programming forces you to think like a computer. This can be very rewarding when dealing with a wide range of IT-related issues from tech support to setting up PPC (pay-per-click) advertising campaigns for a client's web site. Also, as an IT professional, you will be dealing with programmers on a daily basis. Having some understanding of the work they do will help you get along with them better.

Software programs are normally written and compiled for certain hardware \_\_\_\_\_ <sup>14</sup>. It is very important that the software is \_\_\_\_\_ <sup>15</sup> with all the components of the computer. For instance, you cannot run software written for a Windows computer on a Macintosh computer or a Linux computer. Actually, you can, but you need to have special emulation software or a virtual machine installed. Even with this special software installed, it is still normally best to run a program on the kind of computer for which it was intended.

There are two basic kinds of software you need to learn about as an IT professional. The first is \_\_\_\_\_ <sup>16</sup> or proprietary software, which you are not free to modify and improve. An example of this kind of software is Microsoft Windows or Adobe Photoshop. This software model is so popular that some people believe it's the only model there is. But there's a whole other world of software out there.

The other kind of software is called \_\_\_\_\_ <sup>17</sup> software, which is normally free to use and modify (with some restrictions of course). Examples of this type of software include most popular programming languages, operating systems such as Linux, and thousands of applications such as Mozilla Firefox and Open Office.

## **2. Identify the most important key words.**

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**formation** is a fascinating aspect of any language. It involves the creation of new words from existing ones, either by adding a **prefix** or **suffix**, or by changing the word's class (noun, verb, adjective, etc).

**3. Read the text below and complete it with the correct form of the words in brackets.** (booklet page 18)

Without software <sup>1)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (apply), it would be very hard to actually perform any <sup>2)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (meaning) task on a computer unless one was a very talented, fast, and patient programmer. Applications are meant to make users more <sup>3)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (produce) and get work done faster. Their goal should be <sup>4)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (flexible), efficiency, and <sup>5)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (user-friendly).

Today there are thousands of applications for almost every purpose, from writing letters to playing games. Producing software is no longer the lonely profession it once was. Software is a big business and the cycle goes through certain stages and versions before it is released. Applications are released in different versions, including alpha versions, beta versions, release candidates, trial versions, full versions, and upgrade versions. Even an application's <sup>6)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (instruct) are often included in the form of another application called a help file.

Alpha versions of software are normally not released to the public and have known bugs. They are often seen <sup>7)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (intern) as a 'proof of concept'. Avoid alphas unless you are desperate or else being paid as a 'tester'.

Beta versions, sometimes just called 'betas' for short, are a little better. It is common practice nowadays for companies to release public beta versions of software in order to get free, real-world testing and feedback. Betas are very popular and can be downloaded all over the Internet, normally for free. In general you should be wary of beta versions, especially if program <sup>8)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (stable) is important to you. There are exceptions to this rule as well. For instance, Google has a history of excellent beta versions which are more stable than most company's releases.

After the beta stage of software <sup>9)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (develop) come the release candidates (abbreviated RC). There can be one or more of these candidates, and they are normally called RC 1, RC 2, RC 3, etc. The release candidate is very close to what will actually go out as a feature complete 'release'.

The final stage is a 'release'. The release is the real program that you buy in a shop or download. Because of the <sup>10)</sup> \_\_\_\_\_ (complex) in writing PC software, it is likely that bugs will still find their

way into the final release. For this reason, software companies will offer patches to fix any major problems that end users complain loudly about.

**4. Read the following review about STRAVA, an activity tracking app and fill in the gaps with the missing prepositions.** (booklet page 20)

**What is Strava?**

Strava is an activity tracking app that primarily tracks GPS-based activity. Like any GPS app, it runs 1) \_\_\_\_\_ the background while you do your thing. You can use it to run, walk, cycle, hike, canoe, skate, kayak, kitesurf, ski, row, snowboard, snow snowshoe, stand up paddle, surf, swim, and more.



| Pros                                                                                      | Cons                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Rich set of features.<br>Strong emphasis on community.<br>Supports many fitness trackers. | Privacy concerns.<br>Expensive Premium membership. |

**Ease of Use**

The app is easy to use. The download takes almost no time and is free of charge. You can sign 2) \_\_\_\_\_ via Facebook (which enables you to see friends already using STRAVA), however this means you will have to adjust privacy settings 3) \_\_\_\_\_ the Facebook website — not the mobile app or mobile website. You have the option to fill 4) \_\_\_\_\_ a quick profile with a photo, age, gender, height, and weight, which plays a role in calculating calories.

When we are ready to start, all you have to do is select an activity. The opening screen has a very large 'start' button. This starts the timer, and you are ready to roll.

**Features**

Depending 5) \_\_\_\_\_ the activity and plan, STRAVA tracks distance, moving time, elevation, calories, speed, heart rate, and average temperature.

Strava syncs 6) \_\_\_\_\_ a variety of other fitness trackers and running watches, so you don't need to carry a phone 7) \_\_\_\_\_ you to use it. Although the app (which is available 8) \_\_\_\_\_ Android and iOS) offers some privacy settings, you must be willing to make some personal information public, specifically your geolocation data, to get the full Strava experience.

A surprisingly fun aspect of STRAVA is the social connectivity of the program. You are able to 'follow' other athletes, which shows their recent activities 8) \_\_\_\_\_ your feed.

You can also sign 9) \_\_\_\_\_ for challenges according to the activity you want to do. Some challenges, like virtual races, have a leaderboard where you can compete 10) \_\_\_\_\_ other members while

streak challenges ask you to complete a certain number of activities 11) \_\_\_\_\_ a consecutive number of weeks.

### Pricing and Plans

Like many fitness apps, Strava has a freemium model. You can use the app 12) \_\_\_\_\_ free with some limitations. You still get to compete with the free version, but you don't have advanced stats and a number of other features.

It costs €7.99 13) \_\_\_\_\_ month or €59.99 if you pay 14) \_\_\_\_\_ an annual subscription upfront.

### Downsides

Tracking activity is seamless but drains battery life. I recently took Strava 15) \_\_\_\_\_ a five-hour day hike, thinking a hike would be a great activity to track since it would be based 16) \_\_\_\_\_ my location. It certainly worked well for tracking my route, but it had used 17) \_\_\_\_\_ almost all of my phone's battery power.

On the other hand, Strava depends on GPS 18) \_\_\_\_\_ recording activities. In some devices, the GPS does not work properly and Strava will not record effectively.

### The bottom line

Strava is the go-to fitness app for competitive types, but the company needs to do more to address privacy and security concerns.

Sources: <https://mashable.com/review/strava-app-review - 26/05/2021>  
<https://mashable.com/review/strava-app-review - 20/04/2018>

**Writing a review.** A review should be a direct suggestion or opinion on a product's pros and cons. It should be transparent when it comes to sharing important details like price and features and also reflect your technical expertise. (Booklet page 20)

### Key steps when writing a software/app review:

1. Use the software/app (and make notes);
2. List key aspects such as PROS, CONS, FEATURES and PRICE;
3. Add images and videos (particularly if you are writing for the web). This will help readers to see how the software actually looks like and inform their decision;
4. Make information easy to understand (e.g. highlight the most important information and don't be afraid to use bullet points, tables and columns);
5. Suggest/discuss alternative products;
6. Give your genuine personal feedback.



**Bearing in mind the tips above, write a review on an app you use on a regular basis and post it in the PADLET of the class.**